

Sean Toomey

Professor Palmer

Writing as Critical Inquiry

10 May 2026

Brainrot as propaganda

How technocrats are hacking the minds of millions

Last year I filmed a 7 second video in front of BlackRock's midtown offices, quoting a fake statistic. The video went viral, and the next day, [a BlackRock executive was shot dead](#). Comments warned of an imminent FBI raid on my dorm room as I took the video down, shocked at how connected I felt to the tragedy.

My video was one part of a content dogpile that gripped the internet that week. Like a dance that goes too viral before fading into obscurity, in July, a concentrated burst of attention and hatred was cast on BlackRock. But it didn't *have* to be BlackRock. It could have been rival asset manager Silver Lake, Gavin Newsom, or Domino's Pizza.

The targets of a video recommendation algorithm are mostly arbitrary from any one person's perspective. As a creator, I will be the first to admit I cannot predict what "the algorithm" will promote next. The video-watching public, with its endless appetite for novelty, sees this unpredictability as a feature instead of a bug. Even senior engineers at TikTok claim they [do not understand the algorithm they have created](#) because it is "too complicated." But what if one person figured out how to put their finger on the scale? Could enough viral content,

however ironic or immaterial, be woven together to manufacture a desired high-stakes political outcome like an assassination?

In 2026, [the final year that television will be the leading media activity for adults in the US](#), TikTok has become the [primary news source for Gen Z](#). Short-form content has taken on a more important role in society: not just as thirst-traps and “brainrot,” but as the basis for informing the worldview of an entire generation. The influence of short-form content over the information landscape is indisputable, but the influence of the platforms that host it is often less discussed.

On the one hand, there is optimism that these new forms of media will be a democratizing force as information is disseminated by thousands of people instead of a few news networks. Ziad Ahmed, the CEO of a Gen-Z oriented consulting firm, [frames TikTok content as valuable “primary source” journalism](#). With the public conversation open to so many, uncomfortable facts and the full spectrum of opinion are now on display for all to see. On the other hand, is the fact that the majority of feed-based video content is [funneled through the servers of just four companies](#): Google, Meta, ByteDance, and X. And though the diversity of opinion in any one trending topic is notable, it can’t matter nearly as much as the configuration of the medium itself.

As early as 1964, [Marshall McLuhan](#) identified this tension. His analogy of the electric light argued that the content of an innovation (whether it be the shows on television or the videos on TikTok) does not matter as much as the new ways the medium “shapes and controls the forms of human association and action.” In the case of the lightbulb, the content is straightforward: light. Whether it is used for “brain surgery or night baseball” is a matter of indifference, because the medium itself created new ways of life.

The content on TikTok ranges from food reviews to explicitly political declarations, but none of it matters as much as the short-form platform as a *new medium*: the information is delivered to an audience not based on credibility or educational value, like in print media. The information is not even served to the viewer based on a conscious decision to watch, as in the case of Netflix. The revolutionary idea behind short-form content is that engagement matters above all else, even choice and truth.

Take the [algorithm of X](#) as an example, which Elon Musk shared at the start of 2026. According to Fraser Nelson of The Times: “Though the latest X algorithm doesn’t share the weightings used, we know the old ones: A “like” ... is worth a mere 0.5 points. A reply: 13.5. But if your reply sparks the author to reply back? That’s an argument: worth 75 points.” All these numbers are added together and a post is pushed to an audience in proportion to its final score. This simple mathematical system, the arbiter of our new media diet, promotes a post strictly based on the engagement it can drive. The number of views a piece of content gets is not based on critical reviews or even demand, but a “score” in a computer. Consider the curious effects this has on the “forms of human association and action.”

The first effect is that the most popular opinions on short-form platforms are [more simple and polarized](#) than those expressed in longer-form media. This phenomenon is extremely [well documented](#) and has contributed to political polarization in the United States, partially because disagreement drives engagement, and partially because of the *echo chamber*. Since news can be disseminated by anyone on short-form platforms, according to NYU professor Joshua Tucker and others in a [large study](#), misinformation can be “amplified in partisan communities of like-minded individuals, where they go unchallenged due to ranking algorithms that filter out any dissenting voice.”

The second effect of “feeding” content to users algorithmically is the unprecedented control it gives to the feeder, the primary focus of this essay. Although Tiktok argues that their algorithm is too complicated to understand, the wealthiest man on earth figured out how to meddle with X’s algorithm just months after his acquisition of the company.

Three years ago, after Elon Musk’s Super Bowl tweet got 9.1 million views to President Biden’s 23 million, a slack message was sent at 2:36 am on a Monday that mobilized 80 engineers to solve one problem: make Musk the most popular user on X. In less than 24 hours, a solution had been coded: Musk’s tweets would bypass all content filters and be [boosted by a factor of one thousand](#). Based on publicly available information about the X algorithm, nothing about this update would have been hard to manufacture; in a system where a like is worth half a point, a reply is worth 13.5, and anything out of the account @elonmusk is worth a thousand, it’s not hard to see how Musk became the [most followed account](#) on his own platform.

Musk’s decision to artificially inflate his X posts could be interpreted as pathetic and vain. It could also be interpreted as a brilliant strategy that wasn’t anticipated when he first purchased the platform. In 2022, Elon Musk bought X for [\\$44 billion dollars](#), “overpaying” with [a quarter of his \\$180 billion net worth](#). By 2024, one year after Elon Musk boosted the rankings of his own account and faced significant backlash, estimates placed the value of X at [just \\$9 billion dollars](#). But over the next two years, the “impossible” happened: the value of X [shot back up to \\$44 billion dollars](#), and Elon Musk’s personal net worth [shot up to \\$814 billion dollars](#). This was due, in no small part, to the election of Donald Trump.

On the campaign trail of the last election, Elon Musk bet heavily on Trump. Beyond appearing at rallies [high on ketamine](#) and giving [more than \\$300 million dollars](#) to Republicans, according to [David Goldman and Clare Duffy](#) of CNN, he turned his X account into a Pro-Trump

machine, pushing “conspiracy theories about the Biden administration’s immigration policies” and obsessing over the “woke mind virus” to his artificially inflated follower count of hundreds of millions.

In the weeks following Trump’s victory, Musk’s net worth grew by an average of [\\$4 billion dollars a day](#). The value of SpaceX and Tesla, which are [heavily reliant on government subsidies](#), ballooned as their founder was given his own governmental administration to run and photographed in the Oval Office, ingratiated with the President for his support during the election. Still, no rebound was bigger or more [politically contingent](#) than X: it had proven its utility as a political megaphone for Musk. According to analyst Dan Ives, Trump’s election immediately [doubled the value of the platform](#), well after his account had already been reinstated.

Although publicly available information about the manipulation of X’s algorithm ends with Musk’s personal account, more recent evidence suggests it goes deeper. In one study, a [team of researchers led by Chenyan Jia of Northeastern University](#) used L.L.M.s to modify the algorithm of X. Participants in the study downloaded a browser extension which ranked the order of posts on their page differently; one group saw the most partisan content first, while the other group saw it last. After the study concluded, groups who saw the partisan content first viewed the opposing political party two points *more negatively*, while the group who saw it last looked at the opposing party two points *more favorably*. Though four points of political polarization might sound small, it suggests that whoever has access to a backend can steer an entire platform towards a political position. Such an internal policy would only require a browser extension and a few lines of code.

Then, just three weeks ago, a [bombshell study](#) dropped in Nature. Published on February 18th and accessed more than 190,000 times since, it found that on X, “switching from a chronological to an algorithmic feed... shifted political opinion towards more conservative positions, particularly regarding policy priorities, perceptions of criminal investigations into Donald Trump and views on the war in Ukraine.” Whether conservative content is just more optimized for engagement or Musk deliberately engineered the tilt, what matters is that an *algorithm*, not the content itself, is having a measurable impact on political opinions. This is a significant departure from previous literature, which “suggested that the effects of social media feed algorithms reported zero political effects,” and from older studies on platforms owned by [Meta](#) and [Google](#), where “replacing the algorithmically curated feed with a chronological feed did not lead to any detectable effects on users’ polarization or political attitudes, despite causing a substantial change in political content and lowering user engagement with the platforms.”

All this raises a single, damning, unanswerable question: is it intentional? Has Elon Musk created what is arguably the most concentrated instrument of political influence a private individual has ever owned? Nobody knows, because nobody can see inside of his company. The FCC regulates radio and television, forcing standards of decency and requiring broadcasters to [serve “the public interest, convenience, and necessity”](#) as they are held to a certain standard of truth. Even individual creators of internet content can be held accountable for spreading misinformation, like in the infamous case of Alex Jones’ Infowars [being sued for defamation](#) over lies related to the Sandy Hook Massacre. Why isn’t there a regulatory body for *social media platforms* themselves as a class, considering their potential to be compromised and quietly undermine freedom of speech? The government of the United States sees no problem with

American billionaires self-regulating the platforms they own, but it's a risk it won't take with TikTok and its Chinese owners.

On April 24th, 2024, [Public Law 118-50](#) was signed by President Biden. First sponsored by Republican Cathy Anne McMorris Rodgers in the House, one division buried among foreign aid for Ukraine and Israel was the *Protecting Americans from Foreign Adversary Controlled Applications Act*. It would force the Chinese company ByteDance, with its [strategic partnership with the Chinese Ministry of Public Security](#) to sell its app TikTok to a group of American investors.

Reporting on [the \\$14 billion dollar](#) deal indicates that ByteDance will retain ownership of 19.9% of TikTok USDS Joint Venture LLC and the source code to its video recommendation algorithm. The USDS Joint Venture's license to use that algorithm, however, entitles them to modify it as they see fit. The three managing investors: Oracle, Silver Lake, and the MGX fund, each controlling 15% of the new company, will oversee decision-making and the installation of a new board. The remaining 30.1% of the company is split between affiliates of existing ByteDance investors. The three CEOs and majority shareholders of the companies managing the sale of Tiktok — [Larry Ellison](#), [Egon Durban](#), and [Tahnoon bin Zayed Al Nahyan](#) (whose businesses bought a 49% share in the Trump family's cryptocurrency) have mixed to right-leaning political backgrounds. Given Tiktok is not a publicly traded company, not much else has been disclosed about its sale.

There is a legitimate argument to be made about the national security risk that TikTok posed. Before its sale, a [study out of Rutgers University](#) found that “content critical of China was made far less available [on TikTok] than it was on Instagram and YouTube,” which strongly suggested pro-Chinese algorithmic meddling. A year before, [another study in Nature](#) found that

“Republican-seeded accounts [on TikTok] received about 11.5% more co-partisan content than Democratic-seeded accounts, whereas Democratic-seeded accounts were exposed to about 7.5% more cross-partisan content—largely anti-Democratic material—even after adjusting for engagement metrics.” Whether or not this phenomenon was engineered or coincidental, in terms of geopolitical strategy, the Chinese government had a reason to support Trump’s candidacy. Trump-era Republicans tend to show more support for US isolationism, particularly in the [case of a Chinese invasion of Taiwan](#).

No matter what, the sale of TikTok replicates the X problem with American billionaires instead of Chinese ones. If “national security” was the only consideration, the deal succeeded; it secured the data of American TikTok users in the hands of their own government, along with their right to criticize a “foreign adversary” [on a platform that a majority of its users get news from](#). When it comes to securing the impartiality of an algorithm — to promote content based on engagement instead of the preferences of its owners — it only partially succeeds. The deal happened largely under the table to a small group of men that are uniformly elite and unaccountable to the public, however diffuse and institutional they may be.

Importantly, the threat of algorithmically inflated politics is not uniquely conservative. YouTube, [still the largest news platform in the country](#), has a [history of banning right-wing creators](#). The founders of parent company Google, left-leaning [Larry Page](#) and [Sergey Brin](#), still maintain a [majority of voting shares in their company](#). The ownership of Facebook and Instagram is even more concentrated, as Mark Zuckerberg [owns 61% of voting shares](#) in parent company Meta. Though his personal beliefs are [contentious now](#), he has been critical of Trump in the past. Both companies, ultimately run by three men, have the same opportunity to subtly tamper with a feed to serve a political end.

All this power vested in the hands of so few men represents a new kind of monopoly: of information, instead of a tangible commodity. The problem is simple: we *can't* know if the content on our feed was placed there to entertain us, or persuade us. It is my personal belief that Elon Musk did more than inflate the weight of his own posts to help Trump win the election. Whether or not Instagram, YouTube, and the new American TikTok have been compromised in the same way is unclear. What is clear is that social media is no different from the media that came before it; the opinions that are approved in a board room always find a way to be the loudest.

In terms of solutions, no country has figured it out. The European Union got the closest with their [Digital Services Act](#), one of its core goals being to “achieve transparency concerning online ranking systems (driven by algorithms) of products on offer.” This law requires companies to disclose the main parameters of their algorithmic recommendation systems — a great idea. Though it doesn't explicitly *prohibit* the partisan manipulation of an algorithm, the public can't criticize something they don't know about. Not surprisingly, X does not comply with the law.

Last year, the EU [issued a €120 million fine to X](#). Partially due to advertising transparency and issues with their checkmark system, but more notably because the platform made it “unduly difficult for eligible researchers to access its public data, hampering independent scrutiny of systemic risks such as coordinated disinformation, algorithmic amplification, or social-engineering threats,” according to Filip TRUȚĂ of BitDefender. [TikTok and Meta have also been found in violation of the law](#). Though these platforms may argue that the law requires a divestiture of trade secrets, their direct competitor Google had no problem [providing algorithmic data to researchers](#). Elon Musk himself publicly shared information about a version of X's

algorithm not long ago. It seems less likely that these platforms are scared of corporate espionage, and more likely that they have something to hide. Though politically difficult, the only way to solve the problem of “algorithmic amplification” (as the EU calls it) is a hard line: to comply with transparency guidelines or face a ban. A law is only as powerful as the body which enforces it.

At the same time X was fined in Europe, I was anxiously waiting for a knock on my door in America. When I took down my video about BlackRock, I thought I was doing the right thing: preventing the spread of misinformation. I understood the influence of my video as linear, straight out of the mind of one idiot to a slightly more bloodthirsty idiot. What I couldn’t see, at the time, was the middleman. Though I made the video, I was not the one who showed it to two hundred thousand people.

There is nothing secret about the effect of digital echo-chambers on truth, or the loss of nuance in 240 characters. Short-form content lends itself to extremism. A punchy sounding statistic about BlackRock is not the biggest problem, though, when it is balanced by an equally absurd deepfake of George Soros. The bigger, less obvious problem, is when an entire platform throws its massive weight in a single direction. The real influencers are the four billionaires and one “joint venture” who decide what information to feed an entire generation with zero oversight, testing how much bias a user can handle without becoming conscious of the manipulation.

Word Count: 3014

Meta Commentary

This 3014 word paper has 48 citations, which is probably 4x more than anything I've ever written before. I wanted to understand more about the "feed" that I've grown to worship as an avid consumer and creator of social media content. Many videos I've made have been deleted for strange reasons or reached fewer people than I thought they would. Any blackbox, like modern social media algorithms, invites questions, and I just couldn't believe the only answer was "math". Some humans still have to write the equations, after all.

My research process was meandering to say the least. I came into this paper hell-bent on exposing the new owners of TikTok, which turned out to be less important to the story of algorithmic manipulation than Elon Musk and X. How I came to focus on "algorithmic manipulation" instead of the way short form content lends itself to extremism (another paper worth a few thousand words) was really a coincidence based on two freshly published studies that interested me. I never used X, even when it was Twitter, and I never will after learning what I have.

My research and reading took months, but I felt prepared by the time I started this draft. Most of these words were written in the last 48 hours. Claude helped me proofread and find a few sources, but all of these words came out of me.

Works Consulted

- Atske, Sara. "Social Media and News Fact Sheet." *Pew Research Center*, 25 Sept. 2025,
<https://www.pewresearch.org/journalism/fact-sheet/social-media-and-news-fact-sheet/>.
- Butler, Desmond. "Elon Musk's Business Empire Is Built on \$38 Billion in Government Funding." *The Washington Post*, 26 Feb. 2025,
<https://www.washingtonpost.com/technology/interactive/2025/elon-musk-business-government-contracts-funding/>.
- "Commission Preliminarily Finds TikTok and Meta in Breach of Their Transparency Obligations under the Digital Services Act." *Shaping Europe's Digital Future*,
<https://digital-strategy.ec.europa.eu/en/news/commission-preliminarily-finds-tiktok-and-meta-breach-their-transparency-obligations-under-digital>. Accessed 11 May 2026.
- Council of Europe. "Algorithmic Transparency and Accountability of Digital Services." *Council of Europe*, 13 Mar. 2024,
<https://www.obs.coe.int/en/web/observatoire/-/algorithmic-transparency-and-accountability-of-digital-services>.
- Cramer-Flood, Ethan. "US Time Spent with Media 2026." *EMARKETER*, 13 Feb. 2026,
<https://www.emarketer.com/content/us-time-spent-with-media-2026>.
- Egan, Matt. "Elon Musk's X Is Worth Nearly 80% Less Than When He Bought It, Fidelity Estimates." *CNN*, 2 Oct. 2024,
<https://www.cnn.com/2024/10/02/business/elon-musk-twitter-x-fidelity>.
- "Egon Durban." *\$19,250 in Political Contributions for 2008*,
<https://www.campaignmoney.com/political/contributions/egon-durban.asp?cycle=08>.
 Accessed 11 May 2026.

- “Elon Musk.” *Forbes*, <https://www.forbes.com/profile/elon-musk/>. Accessed 11 May 2026.
- Finkelstein, Danit, et al. “Information Manipulation on TikTok and Its Relation to American Users’ Beliefs about China.” *Frontiers in Social Psychology*, vol. 2, Jan. 2025, <https://doi.org/10.3389/frsps.2024.1497434>.
- Flynn, Kerry. “How Gen Z Gets Its News.” *Axios*, 16 Feb. 2024, <https://www.axios.com/2024/02/16/tiktok-news-gen-z-social-media>.
- Gauthier, Germain, et al. “The Political Effects of X’s Feed Algorithm.” *Nature*, vol. 652, no. 8109, Feb. 2026, pp. 416–23, <https://doi.org/10.1038/s41586-026-10098-2>.
- Goldman, David, and Clare Duffy. “Elon Musk May Be on the Brink of Achieving the Impossible: Salvaging His \$44 Billion Investment in X.” *CNN*, 20 Feb. 2025, <https://www.cnn.com/2025/02/20/tech/elon-musk-x-valuation/index.html>.
- González-Bailón, Sandra, et al. “Asymmetric Ideological Segregation in Exposure to Political News on Facebook.” *Science*, July 2023.
- Grind, Kirsten, and Megan Twohey. “Elon Musk Juggled Drugs and Family Drama on Trump’s Campaign Trail.” *The New York Times*, 30 May 2025, <https://www.nytimes.com/2025/05/30/us/elon-musk-drugs-children-trump.html>.
- Halpert, Madeline. “Two Hours of Terror in a New York Skyscraper.” *BBC News*, 29 July 2025, <https://www.bbc.com/news/articles/cy85737235go>.
- Hosseinmardi, Homa, et al. “Causally Estimating the Effect of YouTube’s Recommender System Using Counterfactual Bots.” *Proceedings of the National Academy of Sciences*, vol. 121, no. 8, Feb. 2024, <https://doi.org/10.1073/pnas.2313377121>.

“How Much Is Elon Musk’s Net Worth as of 2023?” *Sportskeeda*,

<https://www.sportskeeda.com/pop-culture/how-much-is-elon-musks-net-worth-as-of-2023>

2. Accessed 11 May 2026.

Ibrahim, Hazem, et al. “Systematic Partisan Content Skews in TikTok During the 2024 US

Elections.” *Nature*, May 2026, pp. 1–8, <https://doi.org/10.1038/s41586-026-10447-1>.

Kessler, Sam. “‘Spy Sheikh’ Bought Secret Stake in Trump Company.” *The Wall Street Journal*,

<https://www.wsj.com/politics/policy/spy-sheikh-secret-stake-trump-crypto-tahnoon-ea4d97e8>.

Kirkland, Colin. *Pew: TikTok Most Popular Social News Source for Gen Z*.

<https://www.mediapost.com/publications/article/411720/pew-tiktok-most-popular-social-news-source-for-gen-z>. Accessed 11 May 2026.

“Larry Page.” *Influence Watch*, 27 Dec. 2018,

<https://www.influencewatch.org/person/larry-page/>.

Lloyd, Noah. “New Research Reveals Algorithms’ Hidden Political Power.” *Northeastern*

Global News, 27 Nov. 2025,

<https://news.northeastern.edu/2025/11/27/social-media-political-polarization-research/>.

McLuhan, Marshall. *Understanding Media: The Extensions of Man*. 1964.

Metzger, Bryan. “Larry Ellison Was Briefly the World’s Richest Man. Here Are the Politicians

He’s Backed over the Years.” *Business Insider*, 28 Nov. 2025,

<https://www.businessinsider.com/larry-ellison-richest-man-backed-politicians-2025-9>.

Meyers, David. “Elon Musk Tops List of 2024 Political Donors, but Five Others Gave More

Than \$100 Million.” *OpenSecrets News*, 26 Mar. 2025,

<https://www.opensecrets.org/news/2025/03/elon-musk-tops-list-of-2024-political-donors-but-six-others-gave-more-than-100-million>.

Mickle, Tripp. “YouTube to Reinstate Accounts Banned over Content Related to the Pandemic and 2020 Election.” *The New York Times*, 23 Sept. 2025,

<https://www.nytimes.com/2025/09/23/technology/youtube-reinstating-banned-accounts-pandemic-election.html>.

Mier, Tomás. “Rolling Stone.” *Rolling Stone*, 15 Feb. 2023,

<https://www.rollingstone.com/culture/culture-news/elon-musk-engineers-twitter-engagement-1234680113/>.

Narkar, Omkar, et al. “Audience Engagement with Political Messaging on YouTube Shorts

(Student Abstract).” *Proceedings of the AAAI Conference on Artificial Intelligence*, vol.

39, no. 28, Apr. 2025, pp. 29439–41, <https://doi.org/10.1609/aaai.v39i28.35280>.

Nelson, Fraser. “Revealed: Elon Musk’s Anger Algorithm That Polarises Our Politics.” *The Times*,

<https://www.thetimes.com/comment/columnists/article/anger-algorithm-far-right-x-twitter-instagram-youtube-0r50ccv6v>. Accessed 11 May 2026.

Northwood, Rhys. “Meta’s Dual-Class Battle: A Governance Crossroads for Investors.” *AInvest*,

17 Apr. 2025,

<https://www.ainvest.com/news/meta-dual-class-battle-governance-crossroads-investors-2504/>.

“Public Interest, Convenience, and Necessity — Encyclopedia of TV & Radio.” *Encyclopedia of TV & Radio*,

<https://www.tvencyclopedia.org/tv-encyclopedia13/public-interest-convenience-and-necessity>. Accessed 11 May 2026.

Richardson, Laurie. "Complying with the Digital Services Act." *Google*, 24 Aug. 2023, <https://blog.google/company-news/inside-google/around-the-globe/google-europe/compl-ying-with-the-digital-services-act/>.

Roscini, Flavia. "How the American Media Landscape Is Polarizing the Country." *The Pardee Atlas Journal of Global Affairs*, <https://sites.bu.edu/pardeeatlas/research-and-policy/back2school/how-the-american-media-landscape-is-polarizing-the-country/>. Accessed 11 May 2026.

Rosen, Phil. "Elon Musk Has Made \$4 Billion Per Day Since Trump Won the Election." *Opening Bell Daily*, 12 Dec. 2024, <https://www.openingbelldailynews.com/p/elon-musk-tesla-stock-economy-trump-election-shareholders-spacex-wealth-billionaire>.

Saini, Manisha. "40+ Daily Social Media Usage Stats & Trends [2026]." *Feedink Sp. Z o.o.*, 28 Jan. 2025, <https://cropink.com/daily-social-media-usage>.

"Sergey Brin." *Influence Watch*, 27 Dec. 2018, <https://www.influencewatch.org/person/sergey-brin/>.

Sherman, Mark. "Supreme Court Rejects Alex Jones' Appeal of \$1.4 Billion Defamation Judgment in Sandy Hook Shooting." *PBS News*, 14 Oct. 2025, <https://www.pbs.org/newshour/nation/supreme-court-rejects-alex-jones-appeal-of-1-4-billion-defamation-judgment-in-sandy-hook-shooting>.

Shi, Jiachen. "Is the Republican Party Moving Away from Taiwan?" *The Diplomat*, 11 Aug. 2025,

<https://thediplomat.com/2025/08/is-the-republican-party-moving-away-from-taiwan/>.

Staunton, Nick. "How X Lost Money for 44 Billion Dollars: Musk's Real Numbers." *European Business Magazine*, 27 Apr. 2026,

<https://europeanbusinessmagazine.com/how-x-actually-makes-money-and-why-a-44-billion-bet-still-hasnt-paid-off/>.

Stokel-Walker, Chris. "How Does TikTok's Algorithm Actually Work?" *Fast Company*, 21 Mar. 2024,

<https://www.fastcompany.com/91065874/researchers-are-finally-figuring-out-how-tiktoks-algorithm-works>.

Thibaut, Kenton. "TikTok's New Ownership Structure Doesn't Solve Security Concerns for Americans." *Atlantic Council*, 27 Jan. 2026,

<https://www.atlanticcouncil.org/dispatches/tiktoks-new-ownership-structure-doesnt-solve-security-concerns-for-americans/>.

Tomasik, Emily, and Katerina Eva Matsa. "1 in 5 Americans Now Regularly Get News on TikTok, up Sharply from 2020." *Pew Research Center*, 25 Sept. 2025,

<https://www.pewresearch.org/short-reads/2025/09/25/1-in-5-americans-now-regularly-get-news-on-tiktok-up-sharply-from-2020/>.

TRUŢĂ, Filip. "Europe Fines X €120 Million in First Enforcement of the Digital Services Act." *Hot for Security*,

<https://www.bitdefender.com/en-us/blog/hotforsecurity/europe-fines-x-120-million-euro-digital-services-act>. Accessed 11 May 2026.

Tucker, Joshua Aaron and Guess, Andrew and Barbera, Pablo and Vaccari, Cristian and Siegel, Alexandra and Siegel, Alexandra and Sanovich, Sergey and Stukal, Denis and Nyhan, Brendan, Social Media, Political Polarization, and Political Disinformation: A Review of the Scientific Literature (March 19, 2018). Available at SSRN:

<https://ssrn.com/abstract=3144139> or <http://dx.doi.org/10.2139/ssrn.3144139>

“Who Has the Most Followers on Twitter? Top 300 (May 2026).” *CreatorsJet.com*,

<https://www.creatorsjet.com/top-300-twitter-influencers>. Accessed 11 May 2026.

Wong, Queenie. “Once a Trump Critic, Mark Zuckerberg Pivots Toward the President.” *Los Angeles Times*, 3 Feb. 2025,

<https://www.latimes.com/business/story/2025-02-03/mark-zuckerberg-once-a-trump-critic-cozies-up-to-the-president>.

搜狐警法. *The Ceremony for the Nationwide Public Security New Media Matrix to Join Toutiao and Douyin Was Held in Beijing*. . 25 Apr. 2019,

https://www.sohu.com/a/310285747_420076.

<https://www.sec.gov/Archives/edgar/data/1652044/000119312524032286/d931712dsc13ga.htm>.

Accessed 11 May 2026.